CHAPTER ELEVEN

TATA STEEL

At the Precipice

The Tata Iron and Steel Company (TISCO), incorporated in 1907 and renamed as Tata Steel in 2005, is Asia's first integrated private steel company. It has an epic history intertwined with India's economic saga and has many firsts to its credit. Developing India's first industrial city (Jamshedpur) and establishing India's first steel (coke) plant in 1918 are amongst them.

By 2023, 'Tata Steel, with an annual crude steel capacity of 34 million tonnes per annum (MnTPA)', qualified to be 'one of the world's most geographically diversified steel producers' and 'one of the few steel operations that are fully integrated—from mining to the manufacturing and marketing of finished products'. The journey of the steel company, spanning more than a century and a decade, has been momentous. And Ratan played a pivotal role in making Tata Steel what it is today. After he took over TISCO in 1993, he navigated it from the brink of disaster. It was not an easy task.

In the early 1990s, TISCO was staring at an existential crisis. It was in poor health and tottering, as the previous management had not set much store by achieving scale or modernization. This was in striking contrast to the frequent modernizations that the company underwent since its inception. For instance, in 1916, the steel company's management had undertaken the 'Greater Extensions Programme', which had raised the steel production more than four and a quarter times in twelve years. It also embarked on modernization programmes in 1937, 1945 and 1954.

The programmes were, however, undertaken in adversarial conditions. Before Independence, it was the stifling policies of the British and after, it